After spending twenty-one months in prison, eighteen of them in solitary confinement, he was finally discharged in July 1990 as a result of the efforts of some Canadian journalists and activists, including members of Amnesty International. On his return to Canada he acquired Canadian citizenship. In November 2015, he was elected Member of Parliament as a Liberal Party candidate from Edmonton Mill Woods constituency. He joined Prime Minster Justin Trudeau's cabinet and served as minister for information and communities from November 2015 to July 2018. He, however, lost his seat to his Conservative Party rival in the last elections held in 2019. [2]

Fake encounter

Amongst the most shocking examples of how a vitiated atmosphere can lead to immense cruelty was a July 1991 incident in Pilibhit district of Uttar Pradesh. On 12 July 1991, a group of Sikh pilgrims from Pilibhit was returning by bus after visiting Nanakmatha, Patna Sahib, Hazur Sahib and other places of pilgrimage. Police intercepted the bus near a bridge at Kachhalghat in Pilibhit district at 11 a.m. and forced ten male Sikh passengers to get off the bus and sit in another vehicle. The rest of the passengers, including the women and children, were taken to a local gurudwara. On the intervening night of 12 and 13 July, the ten Sikhs were taken to a nearby forest and shot dead in a fake encounter by a joint team from three adjoining police stations – Bilsanda, Neuria and Pooranpur. The next day, the policemen claimed that ten Khalistan terrorists, having previous criminal records, had been killed and arms and ammunition had been recovered from them. The police got an autopsy of the dead bodies done before cremating them the same day.

On the basis of a PIL filed by Senior Advocate R.S Sodhi, the Supreme Court entrusted the investigation of the case to the CBI. Filing charges against fifty-seven policemen on 12 June 1991, the CBI described the motive behind the killings as a desire on the part of the local police to earn rewards and recognition for killing 'terrorists'. The CBI court at Lucknow framed charges on 20